

Neon Strike: Project Assessment & Roadmap

How Complete is the Game?

If we are grading this as a **Vertical Slice / Mechanical Prototype**, it is **100% complete**.

You have successfully built a highly polished, mechanically dense foundation that proves the core loop is fun. It has a real spine:

- **A Proven Core Loop:** Spot threat -> React correctly -> Get reward state -> Cash it in -> Adapt build -> Survive next modifier.
- **Ecosystem Variety:** 4 distinct enemy archetypes that force different lane behaviors.
- **Pacing & Arc:** Escalation waves, boss intros, and stage modifiers (affixes).
- **Player Expression:** Build identities through Orb threshold perks.
- **Onboarding:** A non-intrusive but mandatory interactive tutorial system.

If we are grading this as a **Commercial Game Release**, it is about **25% complete**.

The mechanics are locked, but it is currently lacking weight in world texture/atmosphere, run escalation, and deep boss spectacle.

The Roadmap: From Vertical Slice to Full Release

Core Philosophy: Lock identity -> Deepen what exists -> Migrate cleanly -> Expand carefully.

Phase 0: Identity Lock (3–5 Days)

Define the boxer as a real character before adding any more systems.

- **Character Core:** Name, one-sentence essence, power source, fighting philosophy, and SFL fit.
- **Visual Language:** Base aura color, counter-ready color, instinct mode look, and silhouette rules.
- **World Language:** What is this arena? What does "Neon Strike" mean in-universe?
- **Enemy Identity Sheet:** Define the fantasies for the Bruiser, Shield, Assassin, Zoner, Enforcer, and Phantom.
- **Audio Direction:** Genre, BPM feel, sonic profile of counter hits and instinct mode.

Phase 1: Prototype Spectacle Pass (1–2 Weeks)

Stay in the current Canvas prototype and push presentation, not complexity.

- **Boss Intro Pass:** Stronger entrance timing, unique boss color washes, more dramatic title card treatment.
- **Boss Phase Transitions:** Bigger break/overdrive events, stronger hitstop bursts, more

distinct VFX language.

- **Animation Personality Pass:** Better idle bounce, more confident stance, cleaner slip pose, sharper jab, harder torso twist on cross, wider hook arc.
- **Arena Atmosphere Pass:** Add one back layer, one ambient effect, and one foreground/skyline motif.
- **Zoner Readability Pass:** Stronger telegraph line pulse, clearer player-side marker, unique sound signature.

Phase 2: Run Arc Pass (4–6 Days)

Make the run feel intentionally paced.

- **Mini Stage Structure:** Each stage should strictly follow: Opening pressure -> Escalation wave -> Boss warning -> Boss event -> Build choice -> Reset breath.
- **Enemy Composition:** Slightly more deliberate enemy spawning by half-stage to create a natural rhythm.

Phase 3: The Engine Migration (1–2 Weeks)

Move to Phaser or Godot. Do a 1:1 port first. No new mechanics.

- **Port the Math:** Translate current logic (lanes, hitboxes, timings, enemy/boss states) directly into the new engine.
- **System Architecture:** Set up pooling and scene/state management.
- **Controller Support:** Build the foundation for gamepad inputs.
- **Goal:** The migrated version feels exactly the same or better than the prototype, using placeholder visuals.

Phase 4: Art & Audio Implementation (2–3 Weeks)

Bring in Sorceress AI to build the final aesthetic and replace placeholders.

- **Asset Pipeline:** Character silhouettes/sprites/rigs and enemy variants.
- **Environments:** Proper arena layers (parallax).
- **UI & VFX:** Improved UI skin, Counter-hit VFX, Instinct activation VFX, and Boss-specific VFX.
- **Audio:** Real SFX pass and soundtrack implementation.

Phase 5: Controlled Expansion (1–2 Weeks)

Only now add more breadth. Prevent scope sprawl.

- **Limits:** Add at most 1 new enemy archetype, 1 new boss, 3-5 new affixes, and Tier 3 perks for existing Orbs.

Phase 6: Retention & Release Layer (1 Week)

Finalize the Arcade-forward loop.

- **Arcade Priorities:** Grades, score calculations, boss streaks, daily challenges,

leaderboards, and minor cosmetic unlocks.

- **Polish:** Final bug testing, UI responsiveness, and deployment preparation.